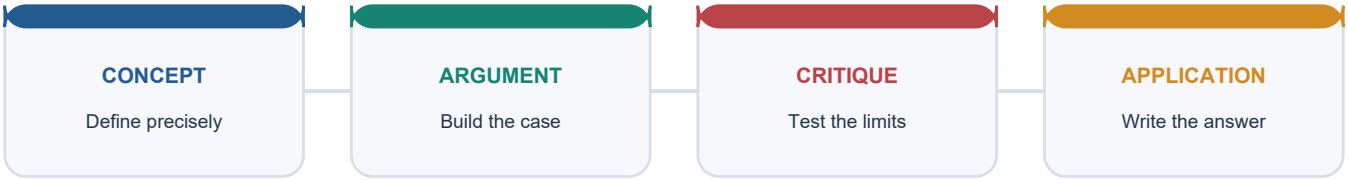
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Post-Gupta India: Harsha & Eastern India - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Post-Gupta India: Harsha & Eastern India - Solved Practice Workbook

Approval: false - awaiting explicit user approval.

This standalone workbook holds the complete bank: 32 original hard MCQs with strict A-B-C-D rotation repeated eight times, 128 separately identifiable option-level explanations tagged [Qnn-A]-[Qnn-D], and 32 unique examiner traps. Remediation is integrated directly into these 32 items (one per rotation block, at every fourth question) rather than held in a separate duplicate remedial block. Formats include multi-statement verification, chronological sequencing, EXCEPT-elimination, term/source matching, correction-based remediation, application and evidence-inference items.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 01 - Q1

Consider the following statements about the post-Gupta political landscape (c. AD 550-750):

1. Later Guptas persisted as a regional line in the middle Ganga belt after the imperial Gupta phase.
2. The Maukharis were based at Kannauj before Pushyabhuti absorption.
3. The Maitrakas were centred at Pataliputra.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 and 2 only B. 1, 2 and 3 C. 2 and 3 only D. 3 only

Answer: A. Statements 1 and 2 are correct; statement 3 wrongly places the Maitrakas at Pataliputra instead of Valabhi.

- [Q01-A] Correct: Later Guptas persisted in the middle Ganga belt and the Maukharis were centred at Kannauj before the Pushyabhutis inherited it through marriage; only statement 3 is wrong.
- [Q01-B] Wrong: this accepts statement 3, but the Maitrakas were centred at Valabhi in the west, not Pataliputra.
- [Q01-C] Wrong: this drops the correct statement 1 and keeps the wrong statement 3.
- [Q01-D] Wrong: this keeps only the incorrect statement and drops both correct ones.

Examiner trap: Candidates who know "Maitrakas = post-Gupta polity" often default-associate them with the Gangetic core rather than checking their actual western Valabhi base.

MCQ 02 - Q2

Prabhakaravardhana is best identified in this package as:

A. the Maukhari ruler defeated by Shashanka B. the Pushyabhuti general whose rise Bana treats as the dynasty's turning point C. the Chalukya king who checked Harsha at the Narmada D. the Gauda ruler who issued gold coinage in Bengal

Answer: B. Harshacharita presents him as the general whose rise made the dynasty formidable.

- [Q02-A] Wrong: this describes Grahavarman's fate, not Prabhakaravardhana's role.
- [Q02-B] Correct: *Harshacharita* presents Prabhakaravardhana as the general whose rise made the Pushyabhuti dynasty formidable.
- [Q02-C] Wrong: this describes Pulakeshin II, a Chalukya ruler, not a Pushyabhuti general.
- [Q02-D] Wrong: this describes Shashanka of Gauda, an eastern rival, not Prabhakaravardhana.

Examiner trap: Candidates confuse the four named rulers of the accession crisis (Prabhakaravardhana, Rajyavardhana, Grahavarman, Shashanka) because they appear close together in the same narrative.

MCQ 03 - Q3

Reading Bana's account of Harsha's accession, which sequence is correct?

A. Grahavarman's death -> Prabhakaravardhana's death -> Rajyavardhana's campaign -> Harsha's rescue of Rajyashri B. Rajyavardhana's death -> Prabhakaravardhana's death -> Grahavarman's death -> Harsha's rescue of Rajyashri C. Prabhakaravardhana's death -> Grahavarman's death and Rajyashri's imprisonment -> Rajyavardhana's campaign and death -> Harsha's rescue of Rajyashri D. Harsha's rescue of Rajyashri -> Prabhakaravardhana's death -> Grahavarman's death -> Rajyavardhana's campaign

Answer: C. This is Bana's actual causal sequence.

- [Q03-A] Wrong: this places Grahavarman's death before Prabhakaravardhana's, reversing the actual sequence.
- [Q03-B] Wrong: this places Rajyavardhana's death before Prabhakaravardhana's, which is chronologically impossible since Rajyavardhana succeeds his father.
- [Q03-C] Correct: Bana's sequence runs death of Prabhakaravardhana, then Grahavarman's killing and Rajyashri's imprisonment, then Rajyavardhana's campaign and death by stratagem, then Harsha's rescue.
- [Q03-D] Wrong: this places the rescue first, before the crisis that necessitates it.

Examiner trap: Sequencing questions punish candidates who remember the named actors but not the causal order linking them.

MCQ 04 - Q4

Which correction best repairs the claim "Harsha inherited a ready-made, stable empire from his father"?

A. Harsha inherited nothing because Prabhakaravardhana had no kingdom. B. Harsha inherited the throne automatically with no crisis at all. C. Harsha's empire was identical in scale to the Mauryan empire. D. Harsha inherited a dynastic and military crisis - Grahavarman's killing, Rajyashri's imprisonment and Rajyavardhana's death - which he then converted into a hegemony through his own consolidation.

Answer: D. This restores "crisis-driven consolidation" as the accurate description.

- [Q04-A] Wrong: Prabhakaravardhana had genuinely built up the Thanesar kingdom; the error is not that there was no kingdom.
- [Q04-B] Wrong: this ignores the entire accession crisis that Bana narrates in detail.
- [Q04-C] Wrong: this repeats the pan-Indian overclaim this package explicitly corrects elsewhere.
- [Q04-D] Correct: this restores "crisis-driven consolidation" as the accurate description of Harsha's accession.

Examiner trap: Candidates fix the wrong part of a flawed sentence; the load-bearing error here is "ready-made," not the fact of succession itself.

MCQ 05 - Q5

Sharma's explanation for Kannauj's rise over Pataliputra rests mainly on:

A. the shift from a money-rich trade-centred imperial order to a military-camp and land-grant based political order, in which Kannauj's fortifiable middle-doab position mattered more B. Kannauj's larger population compared to Pataliputra C. a religious council that permanently relocated the capital D. Kannauj's older status as the Mauryan capital

Answer: A. This is Sharma's structural argument taught throughout the package.

- [Q05-A] Correct: Sharma links Pataliputra's declining centrality to reduced trade/coin use and rising land-based reward, with Kannauj's doab position suiting the new camp-centred order.
- [Q05-B] Wrong: no population comparison is part of Sharma's argument as taught here.
- [Q05-C] Wrong: no such council is part of the evidence; this invents a mechanism.
- [Q05-D] Wrong: Pataliputra, not Kannauj, was the Mauryan capital.

Examiner trap: Candidates supply a plausible-sounding but unevidenced mechanism (population, council) instead of the structural economic-political argument actually taught.

MCQ 06 - Q6

The Aihole inscription is composed by:

A. Bana B. Ravikirti, for the Chalukya court C. Xuanzang D. Harsha himself

Answer: B. Ravikirti composed the Aihole prashasti for Pulakeshin II's Chalukya court.

- [Q06-A] Wrong: Bana composed the *Harshacharita*, Harsha's own court narrative, not Aihole.
- [Q06-B] Correct: Ravikirti composed the Aihole prashasti for the Chalukya court of Pulakeshin II.
- [Q06-C] Wrong: Xuanzang was a Chinese Buddhist pilgrim, unconnected to the Chalukya inscriptional record.
- [Q06-D] Wrong: Harsha is the subject of Aihole's rival claim, not its author.

Examiner trap: Candidates conflate Bana (Harsha's court poet) with Ravikirti (the rival Chalukya court poet) because both compose royal prashasti-style texts about the same confrontation.

MCQ 07 - Q7

Consider the following statements about Harsha's administration:

1. The kingdom was divided into *bhuktis* and *vishayas*.
2. The Banskhera inscription may carry Harsha's own signature.
3. The title *mahasamanta* indicates a fully salaried central bureaucrat with no independent standing.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 only B. 1 and 3 only C. 1 and 2 only D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C. Statement 3 mischaracterises the samanta pattern.

- [Q07-A] Wrong: this drops statement 2, which is directly supported by Upinder's reading of the Banskhera charter.
- [Q07-B] Wrong: statement 3 is incorrect; *mahasamanta* indicates a subordinate ruler with independent standing, not a salaried bureaucrat.
- [Q07-C] Correct: *bhukti-vishaya* division and the Banskhera signature are both supported; statement 3 mischaracterises the samanta pattern.
- [Q07-D] Wrong: this wrongly includes statement 3.

Examiner trap: Candidates assume any royal-sounding title must mean centralised bureaucracy, missing the samanta pattern's actual meaning of delegated, semi-autonomous power.

MCQ 08 - Q8

Which correction best repairs "Harsha's reported army of 100,000 horses and 60,000 elephants is a precise headcount of his standing force"?

A. The figures are accurate because Xuanzang was an eyewitness. B. Harsha had no army at all. C. The figures describe only ceremonial troops, not real warfare. D. The figures are more plausibly explained as including feudatory contingents and rhetorical inflation, not a literal centrally maintained headcount.

Answer: D. Sharma treats the figures as unrealistic unless feudatory support is counted in.

- [Q08-A] Wrong: eyewitness status does not guarantee numerical precision, especially for large round figures.
- [Q08-B] Wrong: this over-corrects into denying the well-attested existence of Harsha's forces.
- [Q08-C] Wrong: this invents a ceremonial-only reading not supported by the sources.
- [Q08-D] Correct: Sharma treats these figures as unrealistic unless feudatory support is counted in, tying military scale to the wider land-based reward system.

Examiner trap: Candidates treat any numeral in a primary-adjacent source as literal data rather than checking it against the structural argument it is meant to illustrate.

MCQ 09 - Q9

Which best fits Harsha's territorial reach?

A. A large direct core across Haryana, most of Uttar Pradesh and parts of Bihar, wider allegiance from rulers such as those of Kamarupa and Valabhi, and a hard limit at the Narmada B. Uncontested rule from Sindh to Kanchi C. Direct administration limited only to Thanesar city D. Full incorporation of the Deccan after defeating Pulakeshin II

Answer: A. This is the graded-sovereignty formula this package requires.

- [Q09-A] Correct: this is the graded-sovereignty formula this package requires - direct core, wider allegiance, frontier limit.
- [Q09-B] Wrong: this restates the pan-Indian overclaim rejected throughout the package.
- [Q09-C] Wrong: this understates his substantial north Indian core.
- [Q09-D] Wrong: Aihole records the opposite - Harsha's check, not his conquest, at Pulakeshin's hands.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly reject overclaim sometimes swing to the opposite error of understating Harsha's genuine northern core.

MCQ 10 - Q10

Which region-evidence pairing is correct?

A. Odisha - Pundravardhanabhukti land-sale plates B. Bengal - Pundravardhanabhukti land-sale plates showing *dinara*-purchased, tax-remitted land C. Assam - Gauda gold coinage under Shashanka D. Odisha - Varman-line Sanskritic state formation

Answer: B. Pundravardhanabhukti is a Bengal locality.

- [Q10-A] Wrong: Pundravardhanabhukti is a Bengal locality, not Odisha.
- [Q10-B] Correct: the Pundravardhanabhukti plates are the Bengal anchor for *dinara*-based land purchase and tax-remitted endowment.
- [Q10-C] Wrong: Gauda and its gold coinage under Shashanka belong to Bengal, not Assam.
- [Q10-D] Wrong: the Varman line and Sanskritic state formation belong to Assam/Kamarupa, not Odisha.

Examiner trap: The three eastern regions (Odisha, Bengal, Assam) share similar processes - grants, Sanskritisation, coinage - so candidates must anchor each named piece of evidence to its correct region.

MCQ 11 - Q11

All of the following are named eastern polities/rulers in this topic EXCEPT:

A. Shashanka of Gauda B. Bhaskaravarman of Kamarupa C. Pulakeshin II of the Chalukyas D. the Varman line of early Kamarupa

Answer: C. Pulakeshin II is a Deccan Chalukya ruler, not an eastern Indian one.

- [Q11-A] Wrong to select: Shashanka of Gauda is a genuine eastern polity/ruler covered in this topic.
- [Q11-B] Wrong to select: Bhaskaravarman of Kamarupa is a genuine eastern ruler covered in this topic.
- [Q11-C] Correct: Pulakeshin II is a Deccan Chalukya ruler, the southern check on Harsha, not an eastern Indian ruler.
- [Q11-D] Wrong to select: the Varman line is the genuine early Kamarupa dynastic line.

Examiner trap: EXCEPT questions punish candidates who pattern-match "ruler mentioned in Topic 22" without checking the specific regional category asked for.

MCQ 12 - Q12

Which correction best repairs "Kamarupa was simply a province directly administered by Harsha"?

A. Kamarupa did not exist before the 7th century. B. Kamarupa was a Chalukya dependency. C. Kamarupa was identical to Gauda. D. Kamarupa was an independent eastern state, already listed in Samudragupta's frontier record and consolidated under Bhaskaravarman, whose rulers may at most have acknowledged Harsha's wider prestige.

Answer: D. This restores Kamarupa's independent, long-attested status.

- [Q12-A] Wrong: Kamarupa is attested from at least the 4th century in Samudragupta's frontier list.
- [Q12-B] Wrong: no evidence connects Kamarupa to the Chalukyas, a Deccan power.
- [Q12-C] Wrong: Kamarupa (Assam) and Gauda (Bengal) are distinct polities under different rulers.
- [Q12-D] Correct: this restores Kamarupa's independent, long-attested status while allowing for looser acknowledgement of Harsha's prestige.

Examiner trap: Candidates default to "if a kingdom is mentioned near Harsha, it must be his province," collapsing diplomatic acknowledgement into direct administration.

MCQ 13 - Q13

The recurring inscriptional terms *bhaga*, *bhoga*, *kara* and *hiranya* in Harsha's records show that:

A. earlier Gupta-era revenue vocabulary continued into Harsha's fiscal administration B. Harsha invented an entirely new taxation system C. these are architectural terms for temple construction D. these terms refer exclusively to military ranks

Answer: A. Upinder notes these as continuing revenue terms.

- [Q13-A] Correct: Upinder explicitly notes these as continuing revenue terms in Harsha's inscriptional vocabulary.
- [Q13-B] Wrong: the terms show continuity, not invention of a new system.
- [Q13-C] Wrong: these are fiscal/revenue terms, not architectural vocabulary.
- [Q13-D] Wrong: these are revenue terms, unconnected to military titles such as *samanta*.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly memorise the four terms sometimes misclassify their function (fiscal vs administrative vs military).

MCQ 14 - Q14

Gauda under Shashanka is most securely dated by Sharma to about:

A. AD 400 B. AD 600 C. AD 900 D. 320 BCE

Answer: B. Sharma states north Bengal had become Gauda under Shashanka by about AD 600.

- [Q14-A] Wrong: this is too early; the Gupta imperial peak, not Gauda under Shashanka, belongs here.
- [Q14-B] Correct: Sharma states that by about AD 600 north Bengal had become Gauda under Shashanka.
- [Q14-C] Wrong: this postdates the Shashanka-Harsha confrontation by roughly three centuries.
- [Q14-D] Wrong: this is a Mauryan-era date, far too early for Shashanka.

Examiner trap: Candidates confuse the loosely remembered "post-Gupta" label with an exact date, losing marks on a directly quotable anchor.

MCQ 15 - Q15

Consider the following statements about Kamarupa:

1. It appears in Samudragupta's frontier list.
2. Its ruling line used the suffix *varman*.
3. Bhaskaravarman extended into Bengal only after Shashanka's death.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 only B. 2 and 3 only C. 1, 2 and 3 D. None of the above

Answer: C. All three statements are supported.

- [Q15-A] Wrong: this drops two further correct statements that this package explicitly supports.
- [Q15-B] Wrong: this wrongly drops statement 1, which is directly supported by Samudragupta's frontier record.
- [Q15-C] Correct: all three statements are supported by the evidence taught in this package.
- [Q15-D] Wrong: at least statement 1 alone is clearly correct, so "none" cannot be right.

Examiner trap: Candidates under-trust a three-statement "all correct" option, assuming test-makers always include at least one false statement.

MCQ 16 - Q16

Which correction best repairs "the Maitrakas of Valabhi were annexed into Harsha's directly administered territory"?

A. The Maitrakas did not exist in this period. B. The Maitrakas were a Bengal dynasty. C. The Maitrakas ruled from Kannauj. D. Harsha is said to have impressed his might on Valabhi and its rulers may have attended his assemblies, but this is acknowledgement of prestige, not proof of direct annexation.

Answer: D. This restores the distinction between acknowledgement and annexation.

- [Q16-A] Wrong: the Maitrakas are a well-attested post-Gupta western dynasty.
- [Q16-B] Wrong: Valabhi, their seat, is in the west (Saurashtra), not Bengal.
- [Q16-C] Wrong: Kannauj is the Pushyabhuti-Maukhari centre, not the Maitraka seat.
- [Q16-D] Correct: this restores the distinction between diplomatic acknowledgement and administrative annexation central to this package's method.

Examiner trap: Candidates repeatedly convert "impressed his might on" or "attended his assembly" into "annexed," missing the graded-sovereignty distinction taught throughout.

MCQ 17 - Q17

The clearance-endowment-hierarchy process described for eastern land grants means that:

A. grants extended cultivation onto waste or fallow land while simultaneously strengthening donee and royal control over resources and labour B. grants had no economic effect and were purely symbolic C. grants abolished all local community participation immediately D. grants only affected land already under full cultivation

Answer: A. This is the dual process taught for eastern grants.

- [Q17-A] Correct: this is the dual process - agrarian expansion plus new landed hierarchy - taught for eastern grants.
- [Q17-B] Wrong: this denies the well-evidenced economic and social effects of the grants.
- [Q17-C] Wrong: Sharma notes cultivators could still be consulted in some village land-sale matters.
- [Q17-D] Wrong: grants specifically targeted waste and fallow land to enable new cultivation.

Examiner trap: Candidates treat land grants as either purely pious (no economic effect) or purely coercive (total community erasure), missing the layered, transitional reality taught here.

MCQ 18 - Q18

The mention of *dinaras* in the Pundravardhanabhukti plates is significant mainly because it shows:

A. Harsha's personal coinage minted at Kannauj B. a monetised land transaction later converted into tax-exempt religious endowment C. Buddhist monastic taxation exclusively D. Roman trade contact with eastern India

Answer: B. The plates show land bought with dinaras, then reclassified through endowment.

- [Q18-A] Wrong: *dinaras* are a coin denomination used in the transaction, not evidence of Harsha's personal minting at Kannauj.
- [Q18-B] Correct: the plates show land bought with *dinaras* and then reclassified as tax-exempt through religious endowment.
- [Q18-C] Wrong: the endowments recorded are not exclusively Buddhist; the charters cover a range of religious and administrative purposes.
- [Q18-D] Wrong: no Roman-trade link is part of this specific evidence.

Examiner trap: Candidates see a coin term and default to a trade-history association (for example Roman coins) rather than the specific land-transaction context taught here.

MCQ 19 - Q19

Arrange the stages of eastern land-grant state formation in the correct order:

A. Endowment -> royal claim over waste land -> cultivation -> purchase B. Cultivation -> purchase -> endowment -> royal claim over waste land C. Royal claim over waste/fallow land -> purchase or charter -> religious/administrative endowment -> expanded cultivation and landed hierarchy D. Purchase -> cultivation -> royal claim over waste land -> endowment

Answer: C. This is the clearance-endowment-hierarchy sequence.

- [Q19-A] Wrong: this begins with endowment, which logically requires a prior claim and transaction to already exist.
- [Q19-B] Wrong: this places cultivation before the royal claim that enables large-scale grants in the first place.
- [Q19-C] Correct: this is the clearance-endowment-hierarchy sequence taught in this package.
- [Q19-D] Wrong: this places purchase before the royal claim over waste land that underlies it.

Examiner trap: Sequencing questions on land grants punish candidates who know the four elements but not their causal ordering.

MCQ 20 - Q20

Which correction best repairs "land grants in the post-Gupta east were only harmless religious charity with no political effect"?

A. Land grants had no religious content at all. B. Land grants applied only to already-cultivated land. C. Land grants were abolished by local communities. D. Land grants reorganised rural power by expanding cultivation and concentrating landed authority in royal and donee hands, even while carrying genuine religious purpose.

Answer: D. This restores the dual religious-and-political character of grants.

- [Q20-A] Wrong: this over-corrects by denying the genuine religious dimension of the endowments.
- [Q20-B] Wrong: grants specifically targeted uncultivated or fallow land, not only existing farmland.
- [Q20-C] Wrong: no evidence supports community abolition of grants.
- [Q20-D] Correct: this restores the dual religious-and-political character of land grants taught throughout this package.

Examiner trap: Candidates fix "charity" claims by denying religion altogether instead of adding the missing political-economic half of the picture.

MCQ 21 - Q21

The coexistence of Sharma's capital-shift thesis with continued eastern gold-coin land purchase and Nalanda's 200-village support base shows that:

A. post-Gupta economic change was regionally uneven rather than a single uniform decline B. all parts of India experienced identical urban collapse C. Sharma's thesis is entirely disproved by eastern evidence D. monetisation increased uniformly across the subcontinent

Answer: A. This is the "uneven transformation" verdict this package requires.

- [Q21-A] Correct: this is the "uneven transformation" verdict this package requires for the economy debate.
- [Q21-B] Wrong: this contradicts the eastern counter-evidence of continued coin use and institutional wealth.
- [Q21-C] Wrong: Sharma's thesis remains useful for Pataliputra versus Kannauj even though it needs regional qualification.
- [Q21-D] Wrong: no uniform subcontinental increase in monetisation is claimed; the picture is regionally mixed.

Examiner trap: Candidates treat competing evidence as proof that one side must be entirely wrong, rather than combining both into a regionally differentiated verdict.

MCQ 22 - Q22

All of the following are cited as counter-indicators against a uniform urban-decline reading EXCEPT:

A. gold-coin land purchase in Bengal charters B. Sharma's observation of Pataliputra's reduced trade centrality C. Shashanka's own gold coinage D. Nalanda's agrarian support base of 200 villages

Answer: B. This is evidence FOR the decline thesis, not a counter-indicator against it.

- [Q22-A] Wrong to select: this is a genuine counter-indicator of continued monetisation in the east.
- [Q22-B] Correct: this is evidence FOR the decline thesis (Pataliputra's contraction), not a counter-indicator against it.
- [Q22-C] Wrong to select: Shashanka's gold coinage is a genuine counter-indicator of continued eastern monetisation.
- [Q22-D] Wrong to select: Nalanda's support base is genuine evidence of continued institutional wealth.

Examiner trap: EXCEPT questions on a two-sided debate punish candidates who fail to sort each fact into the correct side of the argument.

MCQ 23 - Q23

Consider the following statements about post-Gupta social evidence:

1. Rajyashri's near-sati episode is direct evidence of a general social custom among all women.
2. Eastern charters name scribes, merchants, landholders and cultivators participating in land transactions.
3. Xuanzang's penal descriptions may be shaped by an idealising Chinese-audience purpose.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 only B. 1 and 2 only C. 2 and 3 only D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C. Statement 1 over-generalises a single elite episode.

- [Q23-A] Wrong: statement 1 over-generalises a single elite courtly episode into a general social custom.
- [Q23-B] Wrong: this wrongly includes statement 1.
- [Q23-C] Correct: statements 2 and 3 are directly supported; statement 1 over-generalises elite evidence.
- [Q23-D] Wrong: this wrongly includes statement 1.

Examiner trap: Candidates treat a vivid, memorable episode (Rajyashri) as if it were representative statistical evidence rather than a single elite courtly data point.

MCQ 24 - Q24

Which correction best repairs "Xuanzang's account of harsh punishments proves ancient Indian law was uniformly brutal"?

A. Xuanzang never discussed law or punishment. B. Indian law in this period was identical to Chinese law. C. Punishments described by Xuanzang never actually occurred. D. Xuanzang's penal descriptions are valuable but must be read with audience and purpose in mind, since he may idealise or selectively frame Indian order for a Chinese readership.

Answer: D. This applies the audience-and-purpose caution taught for Xuanzang.

- [Q24-A] Wrong: Xuanzang does discuss penal order, so denying this entirely is factually wrong.
- [Q24-B] Wrong: no such equivalence is claimed or supported.
- [Q24-C] Wrong: this over-corrects into blanket denial rather than source-critical qualification.
- [Q24-D] Correct: this applies the audience-and-purpose caution consistently taught for Xuanzang throughout this package.

Examiner trap: Candidates either accept a traveller's claim uncritically or swing to denying it happened at all, missing the graded "valuable but situated evidence" method.

MCQ 25 - Q25

Harsha's religious profile is best summarised as:

A. plural royal idioms - solar association in the early dynasty, Shaiva identity in his own inscriptions and Bana, and strong Buddhist patronage per Xuanzang - used for strategic multi-sect legitimation B. exclusively and permanently Buddhist from birth C. entirely secular in the modern constitutional sense D. exclusively Shaiva with no Buddhist connection at all

Answer: A. This is the "plural royal idioms under one court" formula this package requires.

- [Q25-A] Correct: this is the "plural royal idioms under one court" formula this package requires.
- [Q25-B] Wrong: his own inscriptions and Bana point to Shaiva identity, not exclusive lifelong Buddhism.
- [Q25-C] Wrong: royal religious patronage in this period is explicitly political, not modern secular neutrality.
- [Q25-D] Wrong: Xuanzang's testimony and the tooth-relic episode show strong Buddhist patronage alongside Shaiva identity.

Examiner trap: Candidates pick whichever single sect is mentioned in the specific source they remember best (Bana = Shaiva or Xuanzang = Buddhist) instead of combining both into the plural picture.

MCQ 26 - Q26

At the Prayaga assembly, Xuanzang records worship of which sequence on successive days?

A. Surya, Agni, Ganga B. Buddha, Shiva and the Sun C. Vishnu, Shiva, Buddha D. Indra, Varuna, Agni

Answer: B. Xuanzang records this exact sequence at Prayaga.

- [Q26-A] Wrong: this substitutes an unrelated Vedic triad not attested in the Prayaga account.
- [Q26-B] Correct: Xuanzang records worship of Buddha, Shiva and the Sun on successive days at Prayaga.
- [Q26-C] Wrong: this reorders and substitutes deities not matching the attested sequence.
- [Q26-D] Wrong: this is an unrelated Vedic triad, not the Prayaga sequence.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly recall "multiple deities worshipped" often misremember the exact three named, losing an easily quotable fact.

MCQ 27 - Q27

The gap between Xuanzang's often-quoted 10,000 figure for Nalanda and Yijing's later figure of about 3,000 monks illustrates that:

A. Nalanda's fame is entirely fictional B. the 200-village support base is irrelevant to enrolment figures C. traveller-reported enrolment numbers require critical cross-checking rather than uncritical repetition D. Yijing never visited Nalanda

Answer: C. This is the numerical-caution lesson drawn from comparing the two pilgrims.

- [Q27-A] Wrong: Nalanda's institutional fame and 200-village support are well-attested; only the exact enrolment figure is in question.
- [Q27-B] Wrong: the 200-village support base is directly relevant, since it shows the agrarian scale sustaining the institution regardless of the exact headcount.
- [Q27-C] Correct: this is the numerical-caution lesson this package draws from comparing Xuanzang and Yijing.
- [Q27-D] Wrong: Yijing's own figure is precisely what is being used as a later corroborating check.

Examiner trap: Candidates repeat the more dramatic 10,000 figure because it is more memorable, without applying the taught caution against uncritical traveller numbers.

MCQ 28 - Q28

Which correction best repairs "Nalanda's 7th-century institutional features can be projected straight back onto its 5th-century origins"?

A. Nalanda had no 5th-century origins at all. B. Nalanda only existed after Xuanzang's visit. C. Nalanda's origins and its 7th-century fame are the same single moment. D. Nalanda's institutional development was cumulative: its beginnings lie in the 5th century, while its greatest fame is visible through Xuanzang and Yijing in the 7th century, and later features should not be read back into the earlier period.

Answer: D. This restores the cumulative-development caution.

- [Q28-A] Wrong: Nalanda's 5th-century beginnings are explicitly taught in this package (cross-referenced with Topic 21).
- [Q28-B] Wrong: this contradicts the well-attested earlier origin of the institution.
- [Q28-C] Wrong: this is precisely the anachronism this remedial item corrects.
- [Q28-D] Correct: this restores the cumulative-development caution central to the Nalanda teaching.

Examiner trap: Candidates who know both the 5th-century origin and 7th-century fame sometimes still collapse them into one undifferentiated "Nalanda was always like this" picture.

MCQ 29 - Q29

Consider the following statements about Harsha's literary and courtly world:

1. Bana composed both the *Harshacharita* and the *Kadambari*.
2. The plays *Ratnavali*, *Priyadarshika* and *Nagananda* are traditionally attributed to Harsha.
3. Modern publication-style certainty of authorship applies fully to all these attributed texts.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 and 2 only B. 1, 2 and 3 C. 2 and 3 only D. 3 only

Answer: A. Statement 3 wrongly imports modern authorship certainty.

- [Q29-A] Correct: statements 1 and 2 are directly supported; statement 3 wrongly imports modern authorship certainty onto ancient attribution traditions.
- [Q29-B] Wrong: this wrongly includes statement 3.
- [Q29-C] Wrong: this drops the correct statement 1 and keeps the incorrect statement 3.
- [Q29-D] Wrong: this keeps only the incorrect statement.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly list the attributed works often still overstate the certainty of authorship, missing the authorship-caution point this package insists on.

MCQ 30 - Q30

The Banskhera-Madhuban inscriptions are most useful for studying:

A. religious discourse and multi-sect worship sequences B. offices, dues, administrative vocabulary and the royal camp C. Pulakeshin's memory of checking Harsha D. trans-Asian intellectual exchange and manuscript transport

Answer: B. These charters are the documentary core for Harsha's administration.

- [Q30-A] Wrong: this describes the Prayaga assembly evidence, not the Banskhera-Madhuban charters.
- [Q30-B] Correct: these charters are the documentary core for Harsha's administrative offices, dues and camp-based kingship.
- [Q30-C] Wrong: this describes the Aihole inscription, not Banskhera-Madhuban.
- [Q30-D] Wrong: this describes Xuanzang's and Yijing's role in the Nalanda learning network, not the charters.

Examiner trap: Candidates confuse the four-source comparison matrix (Bana, Xuanzang, charters, Aihole), assigning one source's best use to another.

MCQ 31 - Q31

The historical significance of Topic 22 is best captured as:

A. simple decline with no compensating regional development B. a return to full Mauryan-style centralisation C. simultaneous contraction of imperial-style kingship and creation of new regional state societies in the east, bridging Gupta India to the early medieval order D. a period with no lasting significance for later Indian history

Answer: C. This is the "contraction and creation" verdict.

- [Q31-A] Wrong: this ignores the substantial eastern state-formation evidence taught throughout the package.
- [Q31-B] Wrong: no imperial-scale centralisation returned; Harsha's hegemony remained regionally bounded.
- [Q31-C] Correct: this is the "contraction and creation" verdict that defines Topic 22's historical significance.
- [Q31-D] Wrong: the package explicitly identifies this period as a threshold to the early medieval order.

Examiner trap: Candidates default to whichever single label (decline or restoration) is easiest to remember, missing the dual contraction-and-creation verdict.

MCQ 32 - Q32

Which correction best repairs "the post-Gupta age was simply a dark age with no historical value"?

A. The post-Gupta age was the most prosperous era in all of Indian history. B. The post-Gupta age had no political change of any kind. C. The post-Gupta age is only relevant to Harsha's biography. D. The post-Gupta age is better described as a phase of regional reorganisation - marked by Harsha's bounded north Indian hegemony and dense new eastern state formation - than as either a restored empire or an undifferentiated dark age.

Answer: D. This is the package's final bounded verdict.

- [Q32-A] Wrong: this over-corrects into an equally unsupported triumphalist claim.
- [Q32-B] Wrong: this denies the extensive political change (accession crisis, capital shift, eastern state formation) taught throughout the package.
- [Q32-C] Wrong: this ignores the eastern, administrative and source-critical content that makes up most of the package.
- [Q32-D] Correct: this is the package's final bounded verdict, replacing slogan with process.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly reject "dark age" sometimes overcorrect into an equally unsupported "golden restoration" claim instead of the bounded regional-reorganisation verdict.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - UPSC GS-I Mains 2020 Q2 (exact wording locally preserved)

Pala period is the most significant phase in the history of Buddhism in India. Enumerate. (150 words)

Status: Exact wording preserved locally through the repository's verified package for Topic 10 and the 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger. This topic owns the eastern-transition bridge needed to answer it.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The Pala centuries were the highest late-Indian institutional phase of Buddhism, though the superlative "most significant" must be qualified against earlier Ashokan and early-sangha milestones. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. The Pala world sustained the great mahavihara network of Nalanda, Vikramashila, Odantapuri and Somapura, proving concentration of scholastic institutions in eastern India. 2. Mahayana and Vajrayana thought flourished in these centres, showing doctrinal vitality rather than mere survival. 3. Teachers such as Atisha Dipankara illustrate trans-Himalayan circulation of persons and texts. 4. Pala bronze, stone and palm-leaf manuscript traditions influenced Nepal and Tibet, proving artistic and ritual transmission beyond India. 5. Royal and landed support tied Buddhism to the agrarian-political consolidation of the east after earlier post-Harsha turbulence. [LIMIT] The claim should not erase the foundational significance of early Buddhism, Ashoka or non-royal Buddhist communities. [VERDICT] The Pala phase was therefore the decisive late-classical peak of Indian Buddhism, especially in institutional, scholastic and trans-regional terms. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, gives five named evidence units, ties them to what they prove, adds a qualification and closes with a graded verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **enumerate** requires a concise list of the principal institutional, doctrinal, trans-regional, artistic and patronage contributions, followed by one qualification of the superlative claim.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For this 10-mark, 150-word answer, open with a one-sentence thesis; enumerate four or five named contributions compactly; reserve the final sentence for the Ashokan/early-Buddhist qualification.

How to improve this answer: For "Solved PYQ 1 - GS-I Mains 2020 Q2 (exact wording locally preserved)", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Solved PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2020 Q24 (audited demand; original paper and key not held locally)

Locally audited demand: chronological order involving the Pratihara, Pallava, Chola and Pala dynasties.

Status: Audited routed demand from the 2018-2023 Prelims ledger. Official key unavailable locally.

Answer / route: INFERRED ORDER FROM STANDARD CHRONOLOGY: Pallava -> Gurjara-Pratihara -> Pala -> Imperial Chola.

- Pallavas are securely earlier, with their major political arc beginning centuries before the Palas and imperial Cholas.
- Gurjara-Pratiharas emerge in the 8th century, slightly before or at the very beginning of the Pala line.
- Palas begin in the mid-8th century with Gopala.
- Imperial Cholas belong mainly from the 9th century onward.

Why this earns marks: It states the best-supported chronological route while clearly marking that the official 2020 key is not held locally.

Demand decoding: Treat "Solved PYQ 2 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q24 (audited demand; original paper and key not held locally)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Solved PYQ 2 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q24 (audited demand; original paper and key not held locally)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Solved PYQ 3 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2020 Q97 (audited demand; exact options not held locally)

Locally audited demand: historical places Bhilsa, Dwarasamudra, Girinagar and Sthanesvara in state-dynasty matching.

Status: Routed demand only. Official key unavailable locally; exact option wording not held in the repository.

Answer / route: Use elimination through fixed pairs rather than claim an unheld option letter.

- Dwarasamudra = Hoysala centre (later medieval, not Topic 22's Harsha world).
- Sthanesvara = Thanesar, the Pushyabhuti-Harsha base.
- Girinagar = Junagadh/Girnar-Saurashtra zone in western India.
- Bhilsa = Vidisha/Malwa region in central India.

The likely official option would depend on how the paper paired these places with states or dynasties; since that sheet is not locally present, this workbook honestly stops at the concept route.

Why this earns marks: It gives all secure pairings while refusing to invent a missing option letter.

Demand decoding: Treat "Solved PYQ 3 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q97 (audited demand; exact options not held locally)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Solved PYQ 3 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q97 (audited demand; exact options not held locally)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Solved PYQ 4 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 Q34 (audited demand; original paper and key not held locally)

Locally audited demand: kingdoms of northern India after Gupta decline.

Status: Routed demand from the 2018-2023 Prelims ledger. Official key unavailable locally.

Answer / route: The safe north-Indian post-Gupta cluster includes Later Guptas, Maukharis, Pushyabhutis, Maitrakas and Gauda under Shashanka. If the question mixes northern and southern houses, eliminate Pallavas, Cholas or deeper Deccan lines unless the option specifically asks for a contrast.

This is a concept-solving route, not an official-key claim.

Why this earns marks: It converts a missing paper into a high-quality elimination framework instead of pretending access to an unavailable official key.

Demand decoding: Treat "Solved PYQ 4 - Prelims GS-I 2021 Q34 (audited demand; original paper and key not held locally)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Solved PYQ 4 - Prelims GS-I 2021 Q34 (audited demand; original paper and key not held locally)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Original solved Mains practice

M1. 10 marks - Why is Harsha better described as a north Indian hegemon than a pan-Indian emperor?

Model (10 marks). Harsha is better described as a substantial north Indian hegemon than as a pan-Indian emperor on the Mauryan or Ashokan scale. His direct core covered Thanesar, most of Uttar Pradesh and parts of Bihar, extending probably into Odisha after the Maukhari inheritance, while rulers of Kamarupa and Valabhi may only have acknowledged his superiority rather than accepted his administration. The Aihole inscription records that Pulakeshin II checked him at the Narmada, proving the Deccan lay beyond stable control, and Gauda under Shashanka remained a serious rival whose defeat was not permanently final. Because Bana magnifies the king and Xuanzang admires him, territorial claims drawn from their accounts must be graded rather than taken at face value. Harsha therefore unified much of north India but ruled through layered influence and sharp frontiers, not all-India imperial incorporation. **Why this earns marks:** it names four independent evidence units, states what each proves, and closes with a bounded verdict instead of a triumphalist label.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "M1. 10 marks - Why is Harsha better described as a north Indian hegemon...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a one-sentence thesis; organise four named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference; reserve the final line for the bounded verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add the exact regnal date of the Narmada check and name Ravikirti as Aihole's composer, which sharpens the source-attribution precision an examiner rewards.

M2. 10 marks - How do land grants illuminate the spread of civilisation in eastern India between the 4th and 7th centuries?

Model (10 marks). Eastern land grants show how thinly integrated frontier regions became agrarian, literate and politically ordered state societies between the 4th and 7th centuries. Pundravardhanabhukti plates record fallow land purchased with *dinaras* and then donated for religious purposes, proving both a monetised transaction and agrarian expansion. Odisha's charters and agraharas spread Sanskrit, Brahmanical learning and new fiscal districts into fresh zones, while Sharma notes that scribes, merchants, landholders and even cultivators appear in land transactions, revealing layered local administration rather than pure royal fiat. The king's growing claim over waste land made large-scale grants possible and strengthened donee authority over resources and labour. Because charters privilege elite beneficiaries, they narrate process more clearly than peasant experience. Land grants are therefore best read as key windows into eastern state formation, agrarian growth and social differentiation, not as isolated pious gifts. **Why this earns marks:** it converts records into historical mechanism, cites four named evidence units, and keeps an explicit elite-source caution.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "M2. 10 marks - How do land grants illuminate the spread of civilisation...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a one-sentence thesis; organise four named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference; reserve the final line for the bounded verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add the AD 432-33 starting date for the Pundravardhanabhukti series, which lets the answer open with a precise chronological anchor rather than a general century range.

M3. 15 marks - Assess the importance of Kannauj in the post-Gupta political order.

Model (15 marks). Kannauj became central to the post-Gupta political order because it fused inheritance politics, strategic geography and the prestige of a new sovereignty centre. The Maukhari connection first brought Kannauj into the Pushyabhuti orbit through Rajyashri's marriage to Grahavarman, giving Harsha an inherited claim once the Kannauj throne fell vacant in the succession crisis. Sharma argues that Pataliputra had belonged to a money-rich, trade-linked imperial order, whereas Kannauj suited an age of military camps and land-based reward; its position in the middle doab let it command movement into both the eastern and western Ganga plains by land and water, making it a superior strategic node. Harsha's move from Thanesar converted Kannauj into the chief emblem of north Indian sovereignty, and this value outlived him: the later contest for the city among the Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas proves its enduring symbolic and strategic weight beyond any single ruler. At the same time, Kannauj's rise should not be read as proof of uniform urban collapse elsewhere, since eastern towns and monastic centres retained coin use and institutional wealth in the same period. Kannauj therefore crystallised the shift from an older imperial geography built on trade and centralised administration toward an early medieval politics organised around strategic regional capitals, alliance and inherited legitimacy. **Why this earns marks:** it links alliance, geography, strategy and later significance into one continuous argument instead of a flat descriptive city note, and it explicitly bounds the capital-shift thesis.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "M3. 15 marks - Assess the importance of Kannauj in the post-Gupta political...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: Name the exact Later Gupta/Maukhari predecessor context at Kannauj before Rajyashri's marriage, which would sharpen the inheritance-politics claim with one further precise link in the chain.

M4. 15 marks - Evaluate Xuanzang as a source for Harsha's India.

Model (15 marks). Xuanzang is one of the most valuable sources for Harsha's India, but only when read as a Buddhist pilgrim-intellectual writing later in China for a specific audience. He supplies vivid, otherwise unavailable detail on Kannauj, Harsha's court, the Prayaga assembly and Nalanda's prestige, and his route record illuminates monasteries, pilgrimage networks and the movement of Buddhist texts between India and China. He also preserves fiscal clues such as light taxation and a one-sixth grain share, though these need checking against inscriptional evidence such as the Banskhera and Madhuban charters. Upinder Singh cautions that parts of his account may rest on hearsay or earlier reports rather than direct observation, and that his admiration for Harsha could tip into idealisation for a Tang imperial and monastic readership; his portrait of Harsha as a model Buddhist king therefore needs comparison with Bana and the rival Aihole inscription. His silences matter as much as his narrative, since he does not offer an evenly distributed social survey of Harsha's kingdom. Xuanzang is consequently indispensable but not self-sufficient: his descriptive richness is genuine, yet its historical value only becomes secure once triangulated against literary and epigraphic counter-evidence. **Why this earns marks:** it evaluates value and limitation together, cites five named textual and epigraphic anchors, and closes with a method-aware verdict rather than blanket praise or dismissal.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "M4. 15 marks - Evaluate Xuanzang as a source for Harsha's India.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: Add Yijing as a second, later Chinese-pilgrim control on Xuanzang's Nalanda enrolment figures, which strengthens the source-triangulation method the directive rewards.

M5. 20 marks - Discuss the transition from imperial Gupta rule to regional early medieval formations with special reference to Harsha, Gauda and Kamarupa.

Model (20 marks). The transition from imperial Gupta concentration to the early medieval order was not a simple collapse; it was a redistribution of power into regional state formations, in which Harsha, Gauda and Kamarupa each mark a different point on the same process. After the imperial Guptas, Upinder Singh identifies Later Guptas, Maukharis, Pushyabhutis and Maitrakas as coexisting northern lines, showing fragmentation rather than one clear successor empire. Within this field, Harsha built a genuine north Indian core from Thanesar and Kannauj, proving that reunification remained possible, though only at a bounded regional scale: the Aihole inscription's record of his check by Pulakeshin II at the Narmada marks the firm southern limit of that hegemony. Shashanka's Gauda shows Bengal emerging as an autonomous eastern power rather than a dependent frontier of the Ganga core, issuing its own gold coinage and surviving Harsha's campaigns to remain a serious rival. Kamarupa under Bhaskaravarman illustrates simultaneous state consolidation in the Brahmaputra valley through land grants, Sanskritic kingship and intervention as far as Bengal after Shashanka's death. Across Bengal and Odisha, land charters reveal military camps, new fiscal districts and expanding cultivation, proving that political fragmentation coexisted with stronger, more numerous local state structures rather than an administrative vacuum. Harsha's death in 648 CE without a stable successor, followed by the later struggle for Kannauj among the Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas, confirms that no all-India empire re-emerged, even as the east continued toward eventual Pala consolidation. Because much of this reconstruction rests on literary testimony and routed evidence rather than a dense administrative archive, the argument should be stated with corresponding care. The post-Gupta world is therefore best understood as a field of regional reorganisation, where Harsha, Gauda and Kamarupa each exemplify a different scale and mechanism of early medieval state formation. **Why this earns marks:** it integrates seven named evidence units into one causal argument, balances contraction against creation, and does not mistake regionalisation for anarchy.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "M5. 20 marks - Discuss the transition from imperial Gupta rule to regional...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: Add the Maitrakas of Valabhi as a fourth regional case beside Harsha, Gauda and Kamarupa, which would extend the comparative range without weakening the seven-unit evidence density already present.

M6. 20 marks - Critically examine whether the post-Gupta age was mainly an age of decline or of regional reorganisation.

Model (20 marks). The post-Gupta age contained genuine decline in some earlier imperial and urban forms, but its dominant long-term significance lies in regional reorganisation through land grants, new states, agrarian expansion and reworked sovereignty. Sharma's contrast between a fading Pataliputra and a rising Kannauj captures a real structural shift, from a money-rich, trade-linked imperial centrality toward a more military-camp-centred, land-based political geography, and the growth of land endowment to officers under Harsha points toward decentralising tendencies. Yet Bengal, Odisha and Assam simultaneously show expanding inscriptions, new fiscal districts, land grants, military camps and consolidating state systems, proving that the same century was politically generative rather than merely contracting. Shashanka's Gauda and Bhaskaravarman's Kamarupa demonstrate that the east was entering mature regional visibility, not declining into silence, while Nalanda's growing fame and trans-Asian intellectual traffic reveal concentrated institutional vitality rather than civilisational exhaustion. The Aihole check on Harsha at the Narmada should likewise be read not as proof of general weakness but as evidence of the multiplication of strong regional powers capable of limiting even a substantial hegemon. The later contest for Kannauj, and the eventual consolidation of Pala power, show that this age generated durable regional-centred political structures rather than a lasting vacuum. At the same time, a fair verdict should not deny the local urban contraction, changing monetisation and expanding rural hierarchy that the evidence does support in specific zones. The most defensible judgement is therefore that decline in certain older imperial and urban forms and reorganisation into new regional forms occurred together, with the longer historical arc favouring the language of early medieval reorganisation over that of an undifferentiated dark age. **Why this earns marks:** it directly stages the historiographical debate, deploys seven named evidence units, grants real weight to the decline argument and still reaches a reasoned synthesis rather than a one-sided slogan.

Demand decoding: The directive **critically examine** requires a direct position on "M6. 20 marks - Critically examine whether the post-Gupta age was mainly an age...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: Name Sharma and Upinder Singh explicitly as the two historiographical positions being reconciled, which makes the synthesis verifiably attributable rather than an unattributed balanced tone.